

EXCEL COMBO CHART

Compare two different measures in one chart

09

WHEN TO USE

- Data has **two measures with different units** (e.g., \$ and %).
- Answers: **How do volume and rate move together?**
- Use **Column + Line**, and add a **secondary axis** when the scales differ.

BUSINESS QUESTION

- Did higher sales also mean higher profit margin?
- In which month was the margin highest?
- Are we growing sales at the cost of margin?

DATA EXAMPLE

	A	B	C
1	Month	Sales (\$K)	Margin %
2	Jan	80	12%
3	Feb	95	14%
4	Mar	110	13%
5	Apr	100	11%
6	May	130	16%
7	Jun	150	18%

DATA ANALYST USE CASE

Example: **Sales & Profitability**

QUESTION

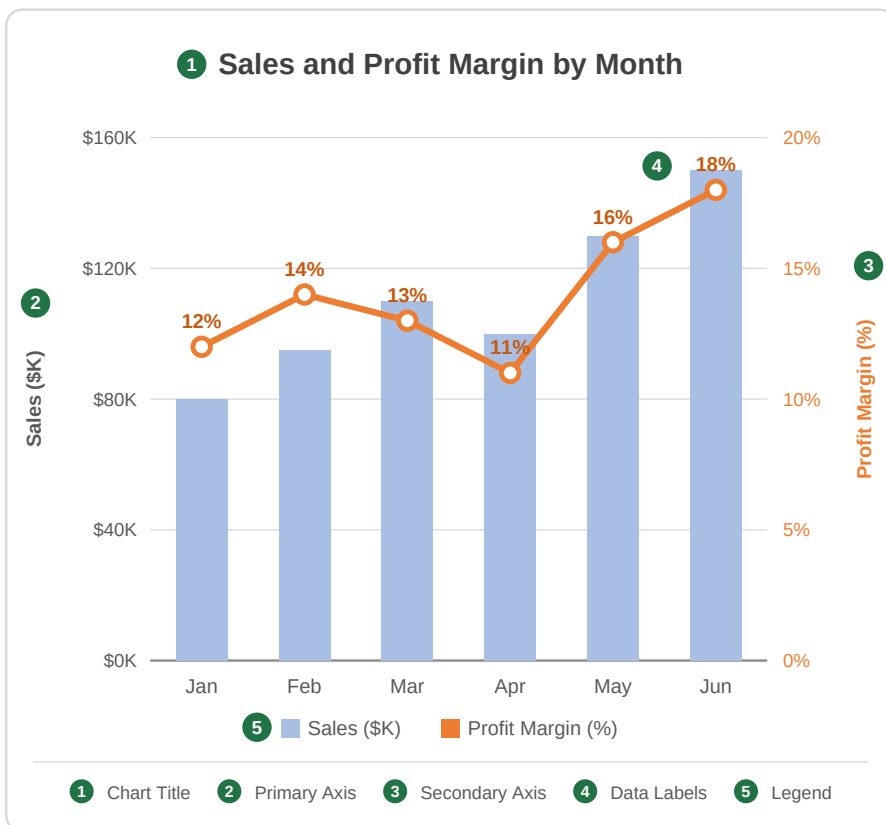
Is our growth profitable?

CHART

Combo Chart (Column + Line)

INSIGHT

Sales nearly doubled (80K to 150K) while margin rose from 12% to 18%: growth is profitable.



HOW TO CREATE IT IN EXCEL



- Select** all the data, including the headers (A1:C7).
- Go to **Insert > Charts** and click **Insert Combo Chart > Create Custom Combo Chart**.
- Set Sales to **Clustered Column**, Margin to **Line**, and tick **Secondary Axis** for Margin.
- Add a **Chart Title** and an axis title for each axis (Sales \$K, Margin %).
- Format**: label only the line, and colour-match each axis to its series.

DO / DON'T

DO ✓

- ✓ Use a secondary axis for different units
- ✓ Label both axes clearly
- ✓ Match axis colour to its series
- ✓ Columns for volume, line for rate

DON'T ✗

- ✗ Combine unrelated measures
- ✗ Leave out the axis titles
- ✗ Use misleading axis scales
- ✗ Add a third measure



DATA ANALYST TIP

Use it when two measures with different units tell one story.

Always label both axes. A secondary axis without titles confuses readers.